

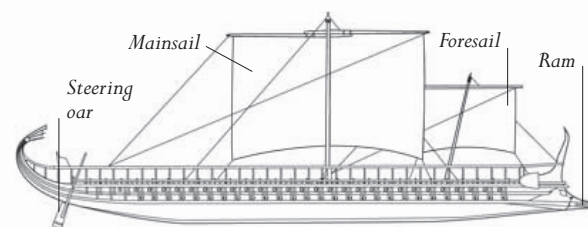
GREEK TRIREME

OLYMPIAS

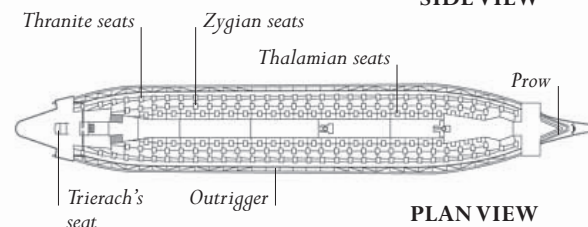
The Greeks were famed for their naval prowess, using light, fast galleys called triremes. No trireme has survived from antiquity, but the *Olympias* is a reconstruction based on historical evidence.

A Greek trireme was a shallow-draught vessel some 35m (115ft) long and less than 6m (20ft) wide. It cruised under sail, but in battle it was propelled by 170 oarsmen – all free citizens – in three tiers: 62 thranites on top, 54 zygyians in the middle, and 54 thalamians at the bottom. With around 30 other men completing the crew, including marine hoplites and archers, it was a crowded vessel. There was room to carry only a few basic supplies and insufficient space for the whole crew to sleep on board.

The *Olympias* was built at Piraeus, Athens, between 1985 and 1987. It proved highly manoeuvrable in sea trials, reaching speeds of almost 8 knots under oar and turning about in twice its own length. In action, a trireme with a skilled helmsman and a disciplined crew could ram an enemy vessel or ride over its oars, then reverse and leave it crippled in the water. If its own hull was holed, a trireme would not sink because it was made from buoyant wood such as pine, poplar, or fir.



SIDE VIEW



PLAN VIEW

▲ THE OLYMPIAS

The side view shows the arrangement of the two sails and the three tiers of oar ports. The plan view shows the position of each individual oarsman's seat.

PROW AND HULL



► SAILING AT SPEED

Under sail, and with a favourable wind, the *Olympias* achieved a speed of almost 11 knots.

◀ BRONZE RAM

A trireme's prow terminated in a bronze-clad ram for holing the hulls of enemy galleys in battle. The ram on the *Olympias* weighs 200kg (440lb).



▲ EAR AND ANCHOR

Sailors dropped and weighed anchor from platforms called *epotides* (ears) near the prow. The ears also protected the thranite oarsmen behind.

► OUTRIGGER

Built out from of the hull, the outriggers allowed the thranites on the upper tier to row from a position outboard of the two lower tiers.

